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Fractured Trust: The Spillover Effects of Police Violence on Satisfaction with Democracy and Political Trust

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Does police violence affect satisfaction with democracy? We answer this question with three studies in Latin America. In a vignette experiment with a Brazilian sample, exposure to violent policing reduced police trust and democratic satisfaction. Using a triple differences-in-differences design with a Chilean panel around the 2019 protests, residents of zones with documented police abuse reported lower political trust and democratic satisfaction than residents of unexposed zones in municipalities without a protest surge. In a cross-national survey of fifteen Latin American countries, respondents who reported police abuse also reported lower police trust, political trust, and democratic satisfaction. In descriptive decompositions, political trust accounts for more of the abuse-satisfaction association than police trust alone. Together, the studies connect violent policing to weaker institutional trust and democratic satisfaction.

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INTRODUCTION

Democratic governments decide how to police their citizens, and the force they authorize can shape how citizens see institutions and the regime. While police violence affects many countries and latitudes across the world, in Latin America it has been chronic. Among other examples of misconduct, law enforcement officers have been involved in unlawful killings, torture, monetary extortion, and association with criminal organizations (Brinks 2007). Reports from Bolivia, Honduras, Colombia, Argentina, El Salvador, Peru, and other countries document widespread abuse (Muñoz and Pappier 2020). In Chile, violence from the police and the military resulted in at least 31 deaths and approximately 3,000 injuries during the 2019 protests (Dammert and Sazo 2020). In Brazil, police killings have exceeded 6,000 per year since 2018 (Bueno and de Lima 2019, 2023). Despite democratization, police and military forces preserve considerable power and influence.

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In this study, we ask whether citizens' experiences with police violence influence their satisfaction with democracy and trust in its institutions. Systematic police violence undermines democratic principles by violating equal citizenship, breaking the rule of law, and eroding perceptions of procedural justice (Bonner 2021; González 2020; Wiatrowski 2016; Manning 2015). Research shows that police violence reduces cooperation with law enforcement (McLean et al. 2024; Drolc and Shoub 2024; Ang et al. 2021; Carr et al. 2007). It also influences political behavior by mobilizing some citizens, particularly in marginalized communities (Reid 2024; Morris and Shoub 2024; Ang and Tebes 2024), shifting policy preferences (Mullinix et al. 2021; Culhane et al. 2016), and shaping perceptions of political efficacy (Branton et al. 2023), highlighting its consequences on democracy.

Satisfaction with democracy is a widely studied measure of system legitimacy (Valgarðsson and Devine 2022). Research has identified several key predictors of this attitude, including economic expectations, socioeconomic status, education, interpersonal trust, crime victimization, government efficacy, and perceived income fairness (Monsiváis-Carrillo and Cantú Ramos 2022; Krieckhaus et al. 2014; Evans and Rose 2012; Fernandez and Kuenzi 2010; Mishler and Rose 1996). However, existing research has paid less attention to police violence as a predictor of democratic satisfaction (DeVylder et al. 2022; Haile et al. 2023; Nägel and Nivette 2023).

Studying the impact of police violence is particularly important in Latin America, where democracies are often described as 'uncivil democracies' (Holston and Caldeira 1998). Although political rights such as voting are established, pervasive violence, impunity, and corrupt judicial systems hinder the full realization of civil rights (Pereira and Davis 2000). Despite the police's central role in society, their influence on democratic satisfaction remains less well studied than other determinants. Instead, scholarly attention tends to focus on state, military, and criminal violence when examining political behavior and attitudes (e.g., Chouhy et al. 2022; Gomes and Alves de Aquino 2018; Trelles and Carreras 2012). In this paper, we theorize that exposure to and victimization by police violence will erode satisfaction with democracy and trust in political institutions.

Police violence can change how citizens judge the institutions that authorize it. For most citizens, the police are the state institution they deal with the most, and in small towns and villages, where the courts and Congress are absent, they are often the only one. Hence, when officers use excessive force,

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citizens see an authority that denies them dignity and a voice (Tyler 2003). To the extent that citizens view the police as part of the state, exposure to police violence can trigger distrust of the political system and dissatisfaction with how democracy works.

We test our theory in three studies. In the first study, an original two-wave vignette experiment in Brazil isolates indirect exposure to police violence, the kind that reaches most citizens through media coverage. Next, we investigate Chile's 2019 social uprising, where police violence was distributed non-uniformly within municipalities, and ask whether residents in census zones exposed to police violence show eroded political trust and democratic satisfaction. Finally, we use LAPOP survey data across fifteen Latin American countries to examine direct victimization by the police and to test whether the pathway we theorize appears in the cross-national record.

In Study 1, participants who read a vignette depicting a violent police encounter reported lower trust in the police and lower satisfaction with democracy than those who read a non-violent scenario. In Study 2, residents of exposed zones in municipalities where protest did not surge became less trusting of political institutions and less satisfied with democracy than residents of unexposed zones, amid a nationwide collapse in police trust. In Study 3, respondents who report police abuse show lower trust in the police, lower political trust, and lower satisfaction with democracy in the pooled sample from fifteen countries. The associations with both trust measures are negative in all fifteen countries, and the pooled association between police abuse and dissatisfaction runs mainly through political trust rather than through trust in the police directly.

This is the first study to theorize and examine the effect of exposure to police violence on satisfaction with democracy (for a review, see Singh and Mayne 2023). Our three studies each measure satisfaction with democracy and trust in the same three institutions, under a different form of exposure. For the study of satisfaction with democracy, our results add police violence to the economic and performance predictors it already examines. For the study of policing, they show that the consequences of police violence reach the institutions of the regime. In a period of concern over democratic backsliding, our study argues for treating police violence as more than a human rights violation. It also threatens democratic legitimacy through negative spillover onto citizens' trust in the institutions democracy rests on and their satisfaction with the system.

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THE SPILLOVER EFFECTS OF POLICE VIOLENCE

The police are a physical embodiment of state authority and, as such, probably the most visible state institution to most ordinary citizens. As a street-level bureaucratic organization, the police deliver policy in the everyday lives of the citizens they are meant to serve (Brodkin 2011). In many places they are the most proximate face of the state, especially in small towns and villages where institutions such as the Judiciary and the Legislature are absent. This visibility is what leads us to ask whether police violence negatively affects broader public opinion about democracy and its institutions.

One crucial distinction between the police and other street-level bureaucrats is that they are *armed*. They carry the legal right to use coercive power to fulfill their mandate, and citizens expect them to apply force proportionately, practically, and appropriately (Kleinig 2014). Following Milani et al.'s (2018) definition, we conceptualize police violence events as police-citizen encounters where the police use force disproportionally to what a given situation would require, thereby inducing excessive and needless violence. This definition can be extended to include psychological, sexual, and neglectful harm, according to the World Health Organization's classification of violence (Cooper et al. 2004). Incidents of such violence against citizens have provoked contentious public debate and a growing literature on policing. These experiences weaken citizens' assessment of procedural justice—the fairness of process and treatment, rather than outcomes (Tyler and Lind 2001), and foster more negative attitudes toward law enforcement, including distrust and perceptions of inefficacy (e.g., Boudreau et al. 2019; Branton et al. 2023; Jackson et al. 2021). That skepticism, in turn, reduces civilian cooperation with local police and local government, lowering, for example, willingness to call the police (Carr et al. 2007; Drolc and Shoub 2024; McLean et al. 2024).

This dynamic should be particularly prevalent in Latin America, where the police have run drug operations, committed killings, kidnappings, torture, extorted money, supplied intelligence to criminal organizations, and mistreated detainees (Brinks 2007). Despite democratization, the military and the police retain significant power in many countries, and law enforcement has itself grown more militarized (Sung et al. 2022). Consistent with this account, public confidence in the police remains low across the region. Most citizens report dissatisfaction with police performance, and only small minorities consider the police well trained or credit them with improving on human rights (Pion-Berlin

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and Carreras 2017, p. 12). Understanding the political consequences of police violence becomes especially important in the region, where rights such as voting and freedom of speech are protected, but impunity, violence, and corruption limit the full realization of civil rights (Pereira and Davis 2000; Holston and Caldeira 1998).

An increasingly large scholarship looks at how and when police violence influences public opinion and political behavior. For instance, in a U.S. survey experiment, Mullinix et al. (2021) find that exposure to text-based coverage or video of controversial police use of force increases immediate support for requiring body cameras. Further, Branton et al. (2023, p. 1278) find that U.S. respondents living in areas with more police killings were less likely to view voting or nonviolent protest as effective. Attitudes toward police violence, however, can be polarized along ideological and partisan lines. In the U.S., conservatives usually hold stable or positive views of law enforcement officials while liberals show greater worry about misconduct (Reny and Newman 2021). Using data from Chile between 2019 and 2022, Sánchez-Barría (2026) finds that right-wing respondents are more likely to justify forceful police repression. Furthermore, in a conjoint experiment in Argentina and Brazil, Laterzo (2024) finds that conservatives generally preferred candidates proposing punitive crime policies. Additionally, authoritarianism beliefs predict support for harsher policing among supporters of populist leaders like Donald Trump and Jair Bolsonaro (Knuckey and Hassan 2022; Vidigal 2022; Womick et al. 2018).

Effects on behavior are more mixed and often racialized. Morris and Shoub (2024) and Ang and Tebes (2024) find that police killings mobilize voter registration and turnout in Black and Hispanic communities, while Markarian (2023) observes a localized drop in Black turnout within a mile of an incident, and Laniyonu (2018) finds lower participation in more-exposed communities in the United Kingdom, again moderated by race. On vote choice, in the United States, Reid (2024) finds that voters in areas with recent police killings favored the Democratic candidate in 2020, net of the usual predictors. Race structures these effects because policing is itself racialized in most contexts, where marginalized racial groups are disproportionately profiled (e.g., French 2013; Greenwald et al. 2003; Correll et al. 2002) and victimized (e.g., Bueno and de Lima 2023; Buehler 2017). Non-white individuals encounter police violence directly or through others in their community, so repeated exposure activates negative perceptions that shape their civic and political action more than among white individuals, who are both

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less victimized and less behaviorally responsive to these incidents (Morris and Shoub 2024; Crabtree and Yadon 2022; Ang and Tebes 2024).

Importantly, systemic and excessive police violence is in tension with democratic principles, so it can degrade citizens' perceptions of how well democracy serves its citizens. We distinguish democratic evaluations as either normative or instrumental. Normative judgments stem from an intrinsic valuation of democracy and its core principles, such as cherishing free speech or equality before the law. Instrumental evaluations treat democracy as a tool for delivering outcomes such as economic growth or social inclusion. Police violence cuts against both. It directly violates core democratic principles, turning institutions meant to protect citizens into sources of fear and departing from the state's obligation to safeguard its citizens. When violence is produced, or not stopped, by a street-level bureaucratic organization, this signals that the system fails to deliver the outcomes citizens expect of it.

Here, we argue that police violence also shapes public opinion about democracy, as it can foster distrust in democratic institutions, and procedural justice underpins that link because it turns on four features of citizens' interactions with authorities: being treated with dignity and respect, having a voice, facing neutral and transparent decisions, and encountering trustworthy motives (Hough et al. 2017; Tyler 2003). More broadly, procedural justice is crucial for maintaining legitimacy, trust, and public confidence in democracy (Saxton 2021; Magalhães and Aguiar-Conraria 2019; Grimes 2017; Magalhães 2014). Violence by law enforcement violates procedural justice and thereby leads to distrust. It weakens confidence in the rule of law and, by extension, the Judiciary, as citizens conclude that officials are not held accountable or bound by the same constraints as ordinary people.

As a spillover effect, we expect police performance that happens in direct contact with citizens to influence the evaluations of the state as a whole. Silva et al. (2022), for instance, find that exposure to police violence lowers trust in local government. Yet, this spillover effect should extend beyond perceptions of local government. The police are an accessible and salient embodiment of state authority. Furthermore, the police sometimes *are* the state, especially where other democratic institutions are absent from daily life, and citizens have no more tangible institution against which to judge the wider system. As citizens form perceptions of institutions and democracy, a violent encounter with the police

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therefore updates beliefs about the fairness and trustworthiness of the overall political system and the institutional structure that mandates and oversees the police. And because marginalized groups are disproportionately targeted, it is their belief in a biased system that attaches most strongly to the justice and legislative institutions charged with equality before the law. Police violence thus travels from the most visible arm of the state to the abstract national institutions.

Police violence can also harm evaluations of democracy by threatening citizens' psychological well-being and basic needs (DeVylder et al. 2017; Geller et al. 2014). Abusive practices violate fundamental needs for respect and dignity, thereby undermining perceptions of belonging and self-worth. Because such violence disproportionately affects communities marginalized by race, ethnicity, or socioeconomic status, it can exacerbate inequality by interfering with the full integration of these groups into local economies and social spaces (DeVylder et al. 2017).

Studies of democratic satisfaction have extensively examined economic expectations, socioeconomic status, education, interpersonal trust, government efficacy, and perceived income fairness (e.g., Krieckhaus et al. 2014; Fernandez and Kuenzi 2010; Mishler and Rose 1996). In a study connecting police misconduct to regime attitudes, Cruz (2015) finds that police corruption and abuse are associated with weaker support for the political order in Central America. We examine three forms of exposure and distinguish satisfaction with democracy from trust in political institutions.

In this paper, we argue that assessments of public opinion about democracy and its institutions should also account for experiences of police violence. These experiences erode citizens' perceptions of procedural justice, which in turn leads to distrust in democratic institutions and shapes their broader evaluations of democracy.

SATISFACTION WITH DEMOCRACY AND TRUST IN ITS INSTITUTIONS

Citizens' assessment of and satisfaction with democracy depend on how they evaluate the system's effectiveness in upholding core democratic norms and its performance in meeting their needs (Canache et al. 2001). Conceptually, satisfaction with democracy indicates a mid-level support for the democratic system. Easton (1965, 1975) originally distinguished diffuse support, directed at the political community and the regime, from specific support, targeted at political authorities. Norris (1999) refined this

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scheme into evaluations of political actors, regime institutions, regime performance, regime principles, and the political community. Satisfaction with democracy sits at the level of regime performance, a middle tier of support between specific support for actors and institutions and support for the regime's principles, such as democracy itself (Norris 1999).

As an instrumental evaluation, satisfaction with democracy is influenced by many factors related to system performance (Singh and Mayne 2023, pp. 204–205). For instance, citizens who hold positive economic expectations, enjoy higher status, or see the income distribution as fair report more satisfaction (Loveless and Binelli 2020; Krieckhaus et al. 2014), and it also rises when citizens perceive the government as efficient and delivering on its promises, since this signals that the system is working and meeting their needs (Linde and Dahlberg 2021; Magalhães 2014).

Satisfaction with democracy has long predicted many political behaviors and attitudes across countries. Although evidence on the relationship between democratic satisfaction and turnout is mixed (Singh and Mayne 2023, p. 198), recent research in Mexico finds a positive correlation between satisfaction with democracy and administratively measured behaviors—turnout, training as a poll worker, and staffing a polling station on Election Day (Vargas et al. 2026). Dissatisfaction can also shape vote choice, making citizens more likely to support populist parties of both the radical right and left (Ramiro 2016; Arzheimer 2009; Lubbers et al. 2002). In Latin America, satisfaction with democracy is often found to be positively correlated with support for democracy (Walker and Kehoe 2013, pp. 194–195; Sarsfield and Echegaray 2006). Claassen and Magalhães (2022, pp. 882–885) test that link within countries, in panel data on 91 democracies: satisfaction has a positive effect on support for democracy, larger than the reverse effect, and violent crime erodes support only through its effect on satisfaction. Support, in turn, is positively associated with subsequent change in democracy within democracies, while satisfaction shows no positive and significant effect once support enters the model (Claassen 2020, pp. 130–131).

Trust in democratic institutions is the other face of these evaluations, conceptually aligned with system support for actors and institutions (Easton 1965, 1975; Norris 1999). Satisfaction with democracy gauges how well the system works in practice, while trust registers whether the institutions that run it are seen as legitimate and fair, and we argue the two move together. Citizens who judge institutional

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processes as fair extend both specific support to particular authorities and diffuse support to the system itself (Hetherington 1998). Procedural justice is what maintains legitimacy and public confidence in democracy (Saxton 2021; Magalhães and Aguiar-Conraria 2019; Grimes 2017; Magalhães 2014), and it is precisely the channel through which experiences with the state's most present institution, the police, reach citizens' evaluations of broader institutions.

Overall, because police violence can diminish both the normative and the instrumental evaluations of the democratic system, we hypothesize the following:

- ***Main Hypothesis:*** *Police violence will negatively affect satisfaction with democracy and trust in its institutions.*

STUDY 1: BRAZIL'S EXPERIMENT

To test our theory, we conducted an original two-wave online survey vignette experiment in Brazil[1]. Fieldwork was conducted throughout October 2023, resulting in 1,004 respondents who completed the first wave, and 624 who completed both waves. We contracted Opinion Box, an online sample recruiter, to recruit subjects and conduct the study using the Qualtrics platform. We chose Brazil as a key case for studying the effects of police violence because of the high number of incidents and its complex social and political dynamics.

The number of police killings in the country has been over six thousand a year since 2018, with 6,429 deaths in 2022 (Bueno and de Lima 2019, 2023). Individuals belonging to non-white racial groups disproportionately experience the impacts of police misconduct. The average percentage of fatal victims who were identified as white was approximately 19.5 from 2018 to 2022 (Bueno and de Lima 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023)[2], which makes police violence a racialized issue in the country. For this reason, we pre-registered race as one of the possible moderators of the effects of exposure to police violence on satisfaction with democracy and political trust.

Brazil's political dynamics around police violence are also polarized. In July 2023, São Paulo, the

[1]Our experimental hypotheses were pre-registered, anonymized materials are in the Supplementary Information (SI).

[2]White Brazilians represent 43.5% of the population, according to the 2022 Census.

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most densely populated state in the country, saw a police operation launched in response to the killing of an officer in the region. Within a month, it had escalated into an extreme case of police violence, with 28 killings (Human Rights Watch 2023). Tarcísio de Freitas, the right-wing State Governor at the time and an ally of far-right former President Jair Bolsonaro, described himself as "extremely satisfied" with the operation, even as residents of the region alleged summary executions and torture of non-criminals. The governor's reaction reflected a broader right-wing trend that took hold with Jair Bolsonaro's 2019 presidential rise, bringing a surge in right-wing populism alongside growing public support for the police and military. Bolsonaro, a former army captain, appointed military personnel throughout his government, including a high-ranking officer as vice-president, and consistently promoted the armed forces' morality and efficiency. That endorsement extended to the police through a narrative that a strong police presence was essential to ending criminal violence, with Bolsonaro's famous sentence "a good criminal is a dead criminal" (Watmough 2021). Given this rhetoric, we also exploratorily examine Bolsonarismo (support for Bolsonaro) and dislike of Bolsonaro as possible moderators.

Additionally, we pre-registered support for (*Petismo*) and opposition to (*antipetismo*) the left-wing Workers' Party (PT) as a moderator, since these two identities anchor Brazil's political polarization. Identification with the PT has been the most—and arguably the only—stable partisan identity in the country for nearly three decades (Carreirão and Rennó 2018; Baker et al. 2016; Samuels 2006), and the party's perceived failures, including corruption scandals and economic crises, have also driven widespread disaffection among voters (Samuels and Zucco 2018).

Drawing from political psychology, among other possible traits, we chose to pre-register trait aggression personality as a possible moderator of the reactions to these violent events, particularly due to its effects on eliciting strong emotional responses to violence. The trait aggression personality battery measures people's aggressive tendencies in everyday life (Buss and Perry 1992). Individuals with high levels of aggression exhibit a pronounced sensitivity to injustices, responding not with mere disapproval but with intense moral outrage. This reaction is deeply rooted in the aggressive person's inherent predisposition towards hostility in the face of perceived threats or violations of justice (Kalmoe 2013). When exposed to incidents of police brutality, aggressive individuals are likely to experience a stronger reaction, perceiving these events as not only violations of individual rights but also as

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emblematic of broader systemic failures.

Having laid out the theoretical rationale for our moderators, we now turn to how the study was designed to capture their effects. In the first wave of Study 1, we measured baseline levels of our outcome variables and our moderators—race, political attachments, and trait aggression[3]. One week after completing the first wave, we re-contacted respondents to complete wave 2, in which they were randomly assigned to read one of two vignettes. They later answered our outcome variable questions, consisting of items about perceptions of procedural justice in the context of the situation described in the vignette (respect, voice, transparency, trustworthiness), one item related to trust in the police, three items related to trust in democratic institutions or "political trust" (trust in Congress, the Presidency, and the Judiciary), and one item tapping on subjects' satisfaction with democracy.

There were two conditions within our manipulation: excessive police violence ($\text{violence}_i = 1$) and a non-violent policing scenario ($\text{violence}_i = 0$). The vignettes were summarized news articles describing an interaction between police officers and a middle-aged man during a traffic stop. The treatment with excessive police violence presents a scenario that escalates to violence when the man has a hard time finding his identification, resulting in an officer shooting the civilian in the leg. Conversely, the non-violent condition describes an appropriate interaction between the person and the police officers, where the person, though nervous, eventually finds his identification with no intervention from the officers. The articles were fictitious, and SI (Section A.6) describes consent, deception, and debriefing.

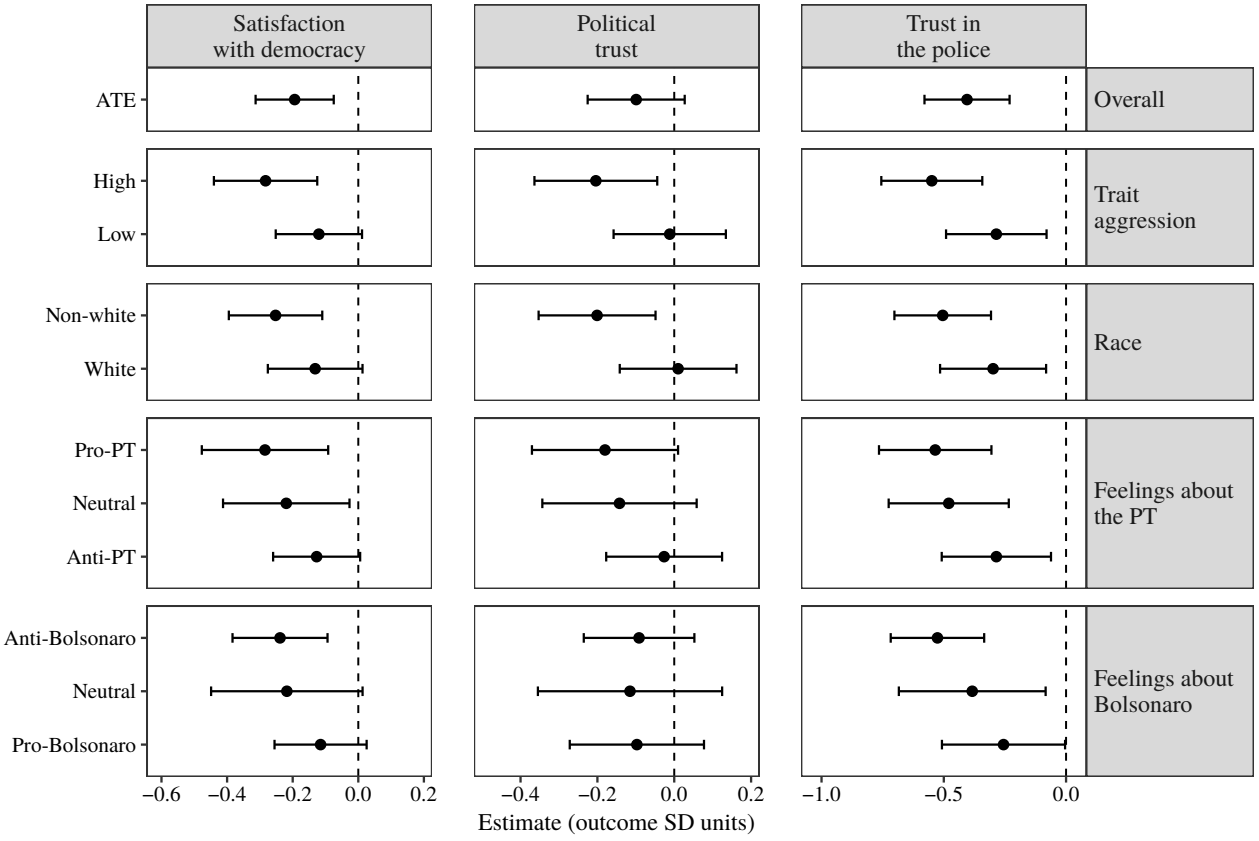
We employ the Two-Way Fixed Effects (TWFE) estimator to assess the impact of this exposure to police violence. We define the treatment variable $D_{it} = \text{violence}_i \times \text{Post}_t$, where $\text{Post}_t = 1$ for observations from wave 2 and $\text{Post}_t = 0$ for wave 1 data. Consequently, $D_{it} = 0$ for all participants in wave 1, and $D_{it} = 1$ for those randomly assigned to the police violence vignette condition during wave 2. Through randomization in the second wave, we ensure that individuals are comparable across both waves in terms of their pre-treatment characteristics and attitudes. Therefore, our design corresponds to a pre-post between-subjects experiment. The Average Treatment Effect (ATE) of interest can be conceptually illustrated as follows:

$$\text{ATE} = \left(\bar{Y}_{\text{wave=2,violence=1}} - \bar{Y}_{\text{wave=1,violence=1}}\right) - \left(\bar{Y}_{\text{wave=2,violence=0}} - \bar{Y}_{\text{wave=1,violence=0}}\right).$$

[3]We also measured other demographics, political interest, turnout, and vote choice in the last presidential election.

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FIGURE 1. Treatment Effects



Note: A five-point item asks about the Workers' Party, running from 1, I hate the party, to 5, I am a *petista*. The pro-PT group answered 4 or 5, the neutral group answered 3, and the anti-PT group answered 1 or 2. The Bolsonaro panel sorts the same way on a matching item about Bolsonaro. Each panel reads its own item alone; items are not combined across panels. High trait aggression is a score above the sample median on the twelve-item battery, with each item rescaled 0 to 1, summed, and the sum rescaled 0 to 1. Non-white respondents did not report their race as white (*branca*). The anti-PT group is the omitted one in the PT panel, and the pro-Bolsonaro group is the omitted one in the Bolsonaro panel. Points: ATE, the average treatment effect, and each group's own effect; bars: 95% confidence intervals.

To further investigate heterogeneity in treatment effects, following our theoretical predictions, we calculate Conditional Average Treatment Effects (CATE) by interacting D with one moderator at a time: feelings about the PT (pro-PT for a 4 or 5 on the five-point party item, neutral for a 3, anti-PT for a 1 or 2, with nobody dropped), a non-white dummy, and a high trait aggression disposition (trait aggression scale > median).[4]

The full regressions, including the overall ATE in the full sample and the CATEs, are reported in

[4]Please refer to the SI for the construction of these scales. Feelings about Bolsonaro, measured the same way on a matching item, appear as an exploratory fifth panel of Figure 1; that moderator was not pre-registered.

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Tables A1 to A3 in the SI. The ATE results indicate a significant negative impact of indirect exposure to police violence on both satisfaction with democracy, at −0.194 (SE 0.061, $p < .001$), and trust in the police, at −0.405 (SE 0.089, $p < .001$). However, we do not find substantial evidence that the treatment directly and unconditionally influenced political trust (−0.099, SE 0.064, $p = .062$).

As shown in Figure 1, the treatment increased distrust in the police in every subgroup. Although the registration specified two-tailed tests, all our theorization is directional, so we report one-sided tests, including for the differences in trust in the police, and two-tailed tests for the Bolsonaro comparisons, which we examine without a prediction.[5] SI Table A19 gives both values for every registered test. The contrast of interest is between pro-PT and anti-PT respondents. The effect is nearly twice as large in the first group, −0.535 (SE 0.117) against −0.285 (SE 0.114), with $p = .030$ for the difference, and the differences by trait aggression ($p = .010$) and by race ($p = .037$) run the same way. For political trust, the treatment left whites, anti-PT respondents, and individuals with low trait aggression unaffected. It was negative for pro-PT respondents (−0.180, SE 0.097, $p = .032$), non-whites (−0.201, SE 0.078, $p = .005$), and aggressive individuals (−0.204, SE 0.081, $p = .006$). The differences from whites and from individuals with low trait aggression are significant as well ($p = .008$ and $p = .015$), while the pro-PT difference is not ($p = .070$). For satisfaction with democracy, the effect is negative in every subgroup and largest among pro-PT respondents (−0.284, SE 0.098, $p = .002$). Its between-group differences are smaller, at $p = .059$ for feelings about the PT, $p = .025$ for trait aggression, and $p = .069$ for race.

Finally, in the SI, we include a table with estimates for the treatment groups on the items measuring perceptions of procedural justice, which test our first registered hypothesis and also serve as a manipulation check. We find that perceptions of procedural justice regarding police officers' behavior in the violent vignette strongly erode perceptions of procedural justice, in contrast to the non-violent

[5]Cho and Abe (2013) argue that theory sets the direction of a research hypothesis, and the hypothesis sets the direction of its statistical test, so testing a directional hypothesis two-tailed breaks the link between them. A researcher who wants a more demanding test, they add, can use a stricter significance level with a one-tailed test. They keep two-tailed tests for cases where existing knowledge does not predict a direction. Hales (2024) adds that a preregistered one-tailed test keeps the false-positive rate of a two-tailed test, gains power when the predicted direction is right, and aligns the test with the researcher's stated theory.

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vignette.

The results provide substantial evidence for our theoretical framework and previous research. Exposure to a police violence scenario sharply reduces trust in the police and lowers satisfaction with democracy. Its effect on political trust points the same way but is indistinguishable from zero overall; negative within-group estimates are detected among non-whites, pro-PT respondents, and individuals high in trait aggression. The between-group comparisons give the clearest evidence for aggression and the weakest for partisanship: six of the nine reported contrasts have $p < .05$, three of them by trait aggression, two by race, and one by feelings about the PT.

STUDY 2: CHILEAN SHOCKS

Through Study 1, we showed evidence that exposure to police violence, manipulated within a controlled vignette experiment, overall decreased trust in the police and satisfaction with democracy, and conditionally decreased political trust, in a context with high levels of police violence. In Study 2, we ask whether the same mechanism holds when exposure is to actual, geographically bounded episodes of police violence rather than a hypothetical scenario, in a country where such violence is low. We focus on Chile, where the 2019 *estallido social* had police repression of protesters concentrated in specific parts of the country, exposing some residents directly while leaving residents of otherwise similar parts less exposed, producing a natural experiment.

We test whether this police violence shock influenced political trust and democratic satisfaction. Because Chile, unlike Brazil, had little police violence before 2019, we can observe how respondents react when police violence is a rupture rather than a routine. Since exposure here is observed rather than assigned, the design captures residents' actual experience of an unanticipated shock.

That shock began on October 18, 2019, when a student-led campaign against a metro fare increase ignited the largest wave of protests in Chile in 30 years. High school students organized mass fare evasions, sit-ins, and demonstrations across Santiago. Within days, the movement expanded nationwide, culminating in over a million Chileans marching in Santiago and hundreds of thousands more joining protests across the country. The government at the time, led by right-wing President Sebastián Piñera, responded with unprecedented police and military repression, deploying armed soldiers and tanks to

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the streets, resembling the repression of Pinochet's dictatorship (1973-1990). State forces used tear gas, rubber bullets, and live ammunition to disperse crowds, using force against civilians regardless of their involvement in the protests. Within weeks, reports of severe human rights violations emerged, including arbitrary arrests, torture, sexual violence, and mutilations caused by rubber bullets, with hundreds of protesters suffering permanent eye injuries (Bonner and Dammert 2022). Social media and independent press captured harrowing images of law enforcement officers violently confronting unarmed civilians. Between October and December 2019, at the height of the *estallido social*, violence from the police and the military resulted in at least 31 deaths, roughly 3,000 injuries, and roughly 20,000 arrests (Dammert and Sazo 2020).

For the year before the *estallido social*, the US State Department reported no arbitrary or unlawful killings by government agents, although it noted numerous reports of police abuse against Mapuche individuals and communities (United States Department of State 2019). This pattern aligns with the historical Chilean trend after the end of the dictatorship in 1990, in which police violence has been less common than in other Latin American countries. Against this baseline, the *estallido social* breaks from the pre-2019 pattern, producing the zone-level police violence events we treat as shocks.

We estimate the impact of these events on political trust and democratic satisfaction using panel data from the Longitudinal Social Study of Chile (ELSOC), a probabilistic and nationally representative survey, fielded seven times between 2016 and 2023. To capture respondent attitudes before and immediately after the *estallido social*, our analytical sample uses the first four waves (2016–2019). Each respondent is geocoded to their residential census zone (*zona censal*), and zone identifiers are merged with geo-referenced police violence records from the National Institute of Human Rights (INDH).

The Institute documented 2,832 victims between October 2019 and March 2020. Physical injury was reported by 88.1% of them, including 153 cases of ocular trauma, 32 resulting in irreversible vision loss (Instituto Nacional de Derechos Humanos 2020).[6] A respondent of the ELSOC survey, therefore, is coded as treated ($D_z = 1$) if INDH recorded a documented case of police violence in their census zone on or before their Wave 4 interview date, and as untreated ($D_z = 0$) if otherwise.[7] Standard errors

[6]We provide the full breakdown by violation type, instrument, and consequence in the SI.

[7]Figure B1 in the SI maps the census zones of the eight municipalities where protest did not surge that contain

are clustered at the census zone level to reflect the spatial unit of treatment assignment.

Since most of the recorded police violence was a state response to protesting, municipalities most likely to register such violence were often also the sites of the heaviest protest. A simple comparison between census zones exposed to police violence and unexposed ones would then confound the effect of police violence with the effect of the protest. Consequently, we separate municipalities by their 2019 protest volume: those where protest did not surge above their historical levels, and those where it did[8]. As a third difference, we then assess whether the response to exposure differs between these two,

$$y_{it} = \sum_{\tau \neq 2018} \left[\beta_\tau + \delta_\tau \mathbf{1}[S_c \geq 1]\right] (D_z \times \mathbf{1}[t = \tau]) + \alpha_i + \gamma_{ct} + \varepsilon_{it}$$

where D_z marks a respondent's census zone as exposed, and S_c measures a municipality's 2019 protest volume against its pre-period baseline in standard deviations. Also, α_i absorbs everything fixed about a respondent, while γ_{ct} absorbs everything that moved a municipality in a given year. Mainly, β_{2019} is the effect of exposure where protest did not surge, and δ_{2019} is how much that effect differs where it did. Their sum is the implied effect in the municipalities that experienced a surge in protest. We use 2018 as the reference year, leaving 2016 and 2017 as placebos. Since all were unexposed before 2019, placebo results answer whether zones that would later be exposed were already differing from those never exposed.[9]

We report the main results in Table 1, with two-tailed p-values. The SI reports the full regression

both exposed and unexposed zones, with the INDH-registered cases as points.

[8] S_c is a municipality's 2019 protest activity minus its pre-period mean, divided by its pre-period standard deviation. Protest activity is the number of COES-recorded events in a municipality-year. The pre-period runs from 2009 to 2018, excluding 2011, since that year's student movement put 44 of the 90 municipalities' event counts above their pre-period mean. The split is coded at one standard deviation in the protest score, leaving 72 of the 90 municipalities with a usable pre-period series at or above it and 18 below, so the no-surge estimates are on the smaller stratum. In SI, *Protest-Intensity Statistic (S_c) Construction*, we report the full construction and the distribution.

[9] Where the joint test of a model's four placebo coefficients gives $p < .25$, we adjust it for differential trends using each respondent's baseline value of the outcome and, if the test still gives $p < .25$, reweight its unexposed respondents. No outcome in Table 1 needs either adjustment. In SI, *Pre-Trend Protocol*, we give the rule and its decision in every Study 2 analysis, and Table B8 reports every estimate in Table 1 with the baseline-outcome trends.

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TABLE 1. Full-sample triple-difference estimates of own-zone police-violence exposure.

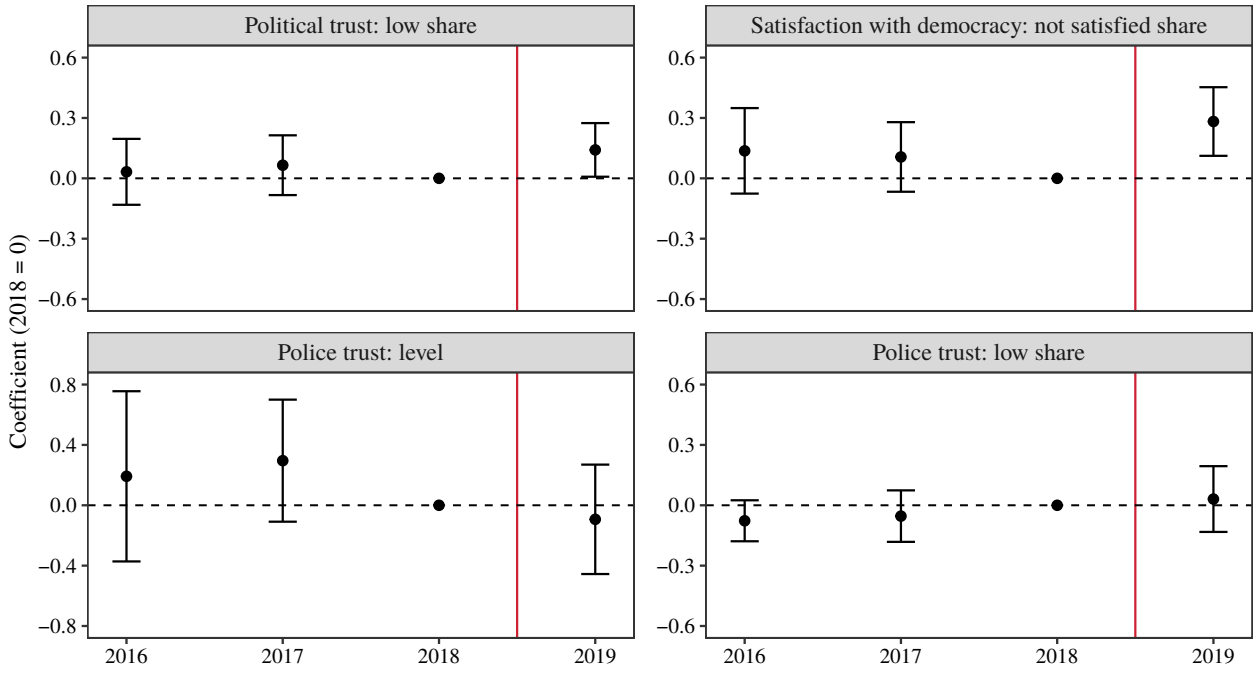
Outcome	Effect in 2019 (SE)	p	Pre-trend p	Exposed / comparison Zones	Exposed / comparison Respondent-waves
Panel A: Municipalities where protest did not surge: treatment DiD					
Political trust: low share	0.141 (0.068)	0.038	0.653	14 / 30	207 / 441
Satisfaction with democracy: not satisfied share	0.282 (0.087)	0.001	0.342	14 / 30	197 / 421
Police trust: level	−0.093 (0.185)	0.615	0.313	14 / 30	223 / 447
Police trust: low share	0.031 (0.083)	0.711	0.333	14 / 30	223 / 447
Panel B: High-minus-low protest: DDD contrast					
Political trust: low share	−0.120 (0.072)	0.098	0.521	123 / 458	1,421 / 5,939
Satisfaction with democracy: not satisfied share	−0.287 (0.094)	0.002	0.708	123 / 458	1,393 / 5,768
Police trust: level	0.219 (0.201)	0.276	0.311	123 / 459	1,452 / 6,059
Police trust: low share	−0.069 (0.088)	0.433	0.672	123 / 459	1,452 / 6,059
Panel C: Municipalities where protest surged: implied treatment DiD					
Political trust: low share	0.021 (0.025)	0.382	0.771	109 / 428	1,214 / 5,498
Satisfaction with democracy: not satisfied share	−0.004 (0.035)	0.902	0.316	109 / 428	1,196 / 5,347
Police trust: level	0.126 (0.078)	0.106	0.831	109 / 429	1,229 / 5,612
Police trust: low share	−0.038 (0.028)	0.169	0.687	109 / 429	1,229 / 5,612

Note: Protest did not surge: $S_c < 1$; protest surged: $S_c \geq 1$. Panel C: Panel A plus Panel B, with a delta-method SE. Respondent and municipality-by-wave fixed effects; reference year 2018. Zone-clustered SEs in parentheses; p two-tailed. Pre-trend p: joint test of the panel's 2016 and 2017 coefficients. Exposed / comparison: zones with an exposed respondent and the other zones in the same municipalities, with exposed and unexposed respondents' respondent-waves there; Panel B counts both strata. Each regression uses 9,676–10,170 respondent-waves in 747–749 zones.

behind it (Table B9). Where protest did not surge, exposure to police violence increases distrust in political institutions by 0.141 (SE 0.068, $p = .038$) and dissatisfaction with democracy by 0.282 (SE 0.087, $p = .001$). We plot the year-by-year coefficients in Figure 2. We interpret below why neither measure of police trust moves detectably. The high-minus-low difference is −0.120 (SE 0.072, $p = .098$) for political distrust and −0.287 (SE 0.094, $p = .002$) for dissatisfaction, very nearly canceling the first. Adding the two leaves an implied effect of 0.021 (SE 0.025, $p = .382$) and −0.004 (SE 0.035, $p = .902$) in the municipalities that surged, neither distinguishable from zero. The pre-trend column in Table 1 jointly tests each panel's 2016 and 2017 coefficients. The joint test of all four pre-period coefficients, the 2016 and 2017 terms and their surge interactions, gives $p = .849$ for political distrust and $p = .348$ for dissatisfaction (SI, Table B11).

The third difference assumes that, without the violence, the gap between exposed and unexposed zones would have changed alike in municipalities with and without a protest surge. Hence, if this assumption holds, we would also expect the gap to have changed alike in the two groups from

FIGURE 2. Exposure Effects by Year, 2016–2019



Note: Coefficients on exposure × wave for municipalities where protest did not surge ($S_c < 1$), from the full-sample DDD; 2018 is the reference wave. Vertical bars: 95% confidence intervals from zone-clustered SEs. Red line: onset of the *estallido*, 18 October 2019. The three share outcomes share one y-axis, −0.6 to 0.6, and can be compared directly; Police trust: level is a coefficient on the 1–5 item and has its own y-axis, −0.8 to 0.8.

2016 to 2018, and we test this implication (SI, Table B7). Only 14 zones are exposed in no-surge municipalities, and with so few, the usual clustered tests reject a true null too often (MacKinnon and Webb 2020). Following MacKinnon et al. (2023), we therefore add jackknife, wild cluster bootstrap, and randomization p-values (SI, Table B15).

We check several possible issues with this design. One is that people in different census zones may report police violence at different rates. For this, we looked at variables in the survey that could predict reporting, and compared zones with and without cases within the same municipality (SI, Table B5). Another is what happens if we change the threshold for classifying a municipality as a surge. We change it from one standard deviation to 1.3 and 1.5 (SI, Table B12). We also change the definition of exposure, counting any case inside the respondent's zone or within 200, 250, or 300 meters of its boundary (SI, Table B11).

Attitudes toward the police could be conditioned along political lines, as we tested in Study 1. We

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TABLE 2. 2019 effect by 2017 vote: Sebastián Piñera versus other candidates

	Not Piñera		Piñera			
Outcome	Effect (SE)	p	Effect (SE)	p	Difference (SE)	p
Political trust: low share	0.278 (0.088)	0.002	0.017 (0.157)	0.914	−0.261 (0.196)	0.186
Satisfaction with democracy: not satisfied share	0.321 (0.125)	0.012	−0.048 (0.235)	0.840	−0.368 (0.226)	0.106
Police trust: level	−0.536 (0.297)	0.074	0.394 (0.343)	0.254	0.930 (0.443)	0.038
Police trust: low share	0.168 (0.140)	0.235	−0.081 (0.147)	0.582	−0.249 (0.157)	0.117

Note: No-surge sample. Effect is the treatment-by-2019 effect within each arm. The Piñera effect is the not-Piñera effect plus the difference, with its standard error from the coefficients' joint covariance. Difference is the vote-by-treatment interaction, with its own p-value. Pooled triple-interaction specification with respondent and municipality-by-wave fixed effects; the police-trust level model adds baseline-outcome trends. Standard errors in parentheses are clustered on the census zone. Respondents with no recorded 2017 first-round vote are dropped.

additionally test the same moderation here with whether a respondent voted or not for the government whose police carried out the repression. In Table 2 we report that, among those who did not vote for the incumbent President, right-wing Piñera, exposure decreases police trust by −0.536, and, among those who did, it increases it by +0.394. The difference between those two responses is +0.930 (p = .038); for the low police-trust share it is −0.249 (p = .117), and none of the other differences reaches significance. The repression occurred in the zones where these respondents live, and yet those who voted for the government that ordered the police into the streets did not lower their trust in the police, and if anything raised it. Voting for the government appears to make close experiences with police violence go from negative evidence against the police into something closer to vindication of it.

These political differences point to our interpretation of why we do not find effects on police trust in the main analysis. Trust in the *Carabineros* decreased everywhere, and the share of respondents placing themselves at the lowest level of police trust in municipalities where protest did not surge rose from 11.4% in 2018 to 27.8% in 2019 in exposed zones and, almost equally, from 12.4% to 26.8% in unexposed zones. The raw change among unexposed respondents was −0.511 scale points, and the municipality-by-year term absorbs exactly that kind of common movement. A nationally televised failure leaves little room for local exposure to influence trust. Democratic satisfaction and trust in political institutions also fell nationally, by a similar or larger amount. Among unexposed respondents where protest did not surge, the share at the floor rose by 0.221 for dissatisfaction and 0.142 for political distrust, against 0.144 for police distrust. However, close exposure added 0.282 and 0.141 to the two political outcomes and 0.031 to police distrust.

The results from this study provide evidence of a decline in trust in democratic institutions and in

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satisfaction in democracy after local police violence exposure in municipalities where protest did not surge.

STUDY 3: CROSS-NATIONAL EVIDENCE

Studies 1 and 2 estimate the effect of exposure to police violence within single countries. In Study 3, we address whether this pattern generalizes across Latin America. To assess the extent of the association, we use the 2008 wave of LAPOP. It is the only cross-national wave ever fielded in the region that asks respondents both our dependent variables of interest and whether the police mistreated them, a measure of direct self-reported exposure to violence: "In the past 12 months, has any police officer mistreated you verbally, physically, or assaulted you? How many times?"[10]. We read results from this study as a broader corroboration of the pattern.

Only 5.8% of respondents report abuse, and this exposure is neither assigned nor quasi-random. We therefore control for two available exposures that could explain exposure to police violence, along with multiple other covariates. Crime victimization is included so that the estimate does not simply reflect who encounters crime, and police bribe solicitation so that it does not reflect those who encounter corrupt officials. Demographic and socioeconomic covariates are also added. We estimate a survey-weighted linear multilevel regression for each outcome. Each country receives its own intercept and its own slope on police abuse; the controls enter with one slope shared across countries.

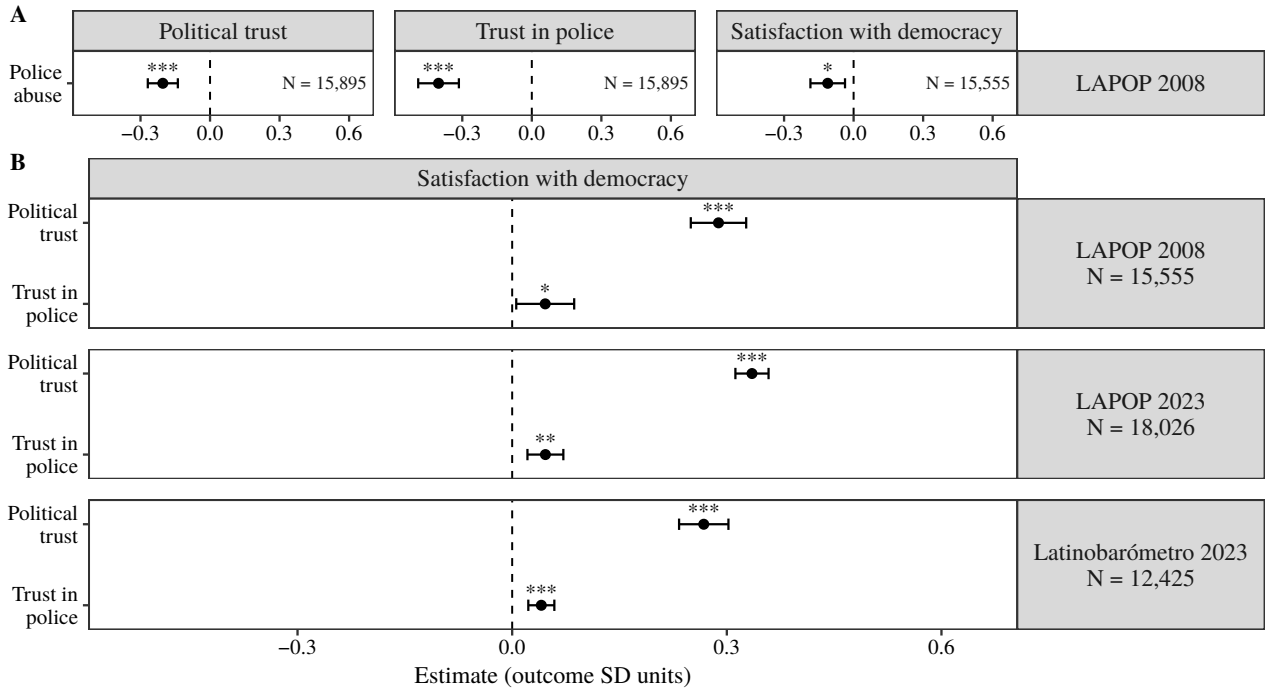
Respondents who report police abuse show lower trust in police, lower political trust, and lower satisfaction with democracy (Figure 3, Panel A; country by country in SI Figure C1). The drop is largest for trust in the police, at −0.402 (SE 0.045, $p < .001$), but it also appears for the legislature, the executive, and the courts taken together, at −0.204 (SE 0.033, $p < .001$), and for satisfaction with democracy, at −0.112 (SE 0.038, $p = .014$). Reporting abuse corresponds to about three-quarters of a point of trust in the police on its seven-point scale, and to under a tenth of a point of satisfaction with democracy on its four-point scale.

All evidence found so far points to the spillover we theorize, with police violence lowering

[10]The item was asked of all respondents, with "don't-know" responses coded to missing. The item records a count; we code victimization as one or more incidents.

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FIGURE 3. Police Abuse, Trust, and Satisfaction with Democracy.



Note: Panel A: police abuse and each outcome, LAPOP 2008. Panel B: trust and satisfaction with democracy in three surveys. All estimates use survey weights; outcomes are standardized within dataset, so coefficients are in standard deviation units. Every row comes from a multilevel model that gives each country its own intercept and its own slope on the predictor of interest. Bars are 95% confidence intervals. $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$, $^{***}p < 0.001$ (two-tailed; Satterthwaite df). All three datasets cover the same fifteen countries. Estimation details and full coefficients in the SI.

evaluations beyond the police. A violent encounter signals not only about this one institution, but about the fairness and trustworthiness of the state that arms and authorizes it. Because the police are the institution most present in daily life, that judgment travels from them to the national institutions. That is, abuse can lower trust in the police, trust in democratic institutions and satisfaction with democracy, and our theory does not fix the order in which they fall. Trust is where that judgment registers, and satisfaction with democracy is where it surfaces, as a verdict on how the system works in practice.

Therefore, next, we ask whether the steps from trust to satisfaction with democracy that this mechanism requires are present in the available datasets. In Figure 3, Panel B, we report these steps. With the 2008 LAPOP, fitting the trust-to-satisfaction specification, with controls, political trust predicts satisfaction with democracy at 0.288 (SE 0.020, $p < .001$) per standard deviation of trust, about two and a half times the size of the police-abuse coefficient on the same outcome. We explore two 2023 surveys that reproduce this fifteen years later and find that political trust enters at 0.268 (SE 0.018,

$p < .001$) in the Latinobarómetro and 0.335 (SE 0.012, $p < .001$) in LAPOP, trust in police at 0.041 (SE 0.009, $p < .001$) and 0.046 (SE 0.013, $p = .003$). Political trust is the far stronger predictor, and its coefficient is positive in all fifteen countries of both 2023 surveys. The police-trust coefficient is positive in all fifteen Latinobarómetro countries and in fourteen of the fifteen LAPOP countries, and the one negative coefficient sits near zero.

The two trust measures are recorded at the same moment, so rather than assume a mediation order, we fit either ordering and present the results in Table 3. If we treat trust in police as the upstream predictor, most of its association with democratic satisfaction runs through political trust: 75.9% in LAPOP 2023 and 67.2% in the Latinobarómetro 2023. Alternatively, almost none of political trust's association runs through trust in police: 5.8% in the Latinobarómetro and 6.6% in LAPOP. [11]

On LAPOP 2008, where the exposure is abuse rather than trust, the decomposition separates the two channels, and both orderings put the route through political trust. Reading political trust as the first mediator, 51.6% of abuse's association with satisfaction runs through it alone against 11.7% through trust in police alone, with 4.5% through both in series and 32.2% direct. Reading trust in police first, its association reaches satisfaction almost entirely by passing into political trust, 53.7% serially against 16.1% through trust in police alone.

Three robustness checks suggest this pattern is not an artifact of model specification. First, adding the two trust measures increases the explained variance from 0.187 to 0.264 in the Latinobarómetro, and from 0.085 to 0.210 in LAPOP. Second, the political trust coefficient lowers only modestly (from 0.268 to 0.241) when controlling for winner-loser status and corruption perceptions, which are common predictors of this variable, suggesting it is not simply a proxy for other regime judgments. Third, any unmeasured confounder would need to be strongly associated with both trust and satisfaction to explain away the observed effect. We calculate the necessary threshold using the E-value (VanderWeele and Ding 2017), which is 2.03 in one survey and 2.22 in the other, whereas the strongest measured

[11] We note that the two trust measures are not statistically independent. Corrected for measurement error in political trust, they correlate at .49 to .56. Although our analysis suggests political trust carries the direct, cross-sectional association, and trust in police reaches satisfaction with democracy mainly through it, these measures are recorded at the same time. Thus, this is not a definitive test of mediation, and we present these results as descriptive.

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TABLE 3. Mediation decomposition by ordering and dataset.

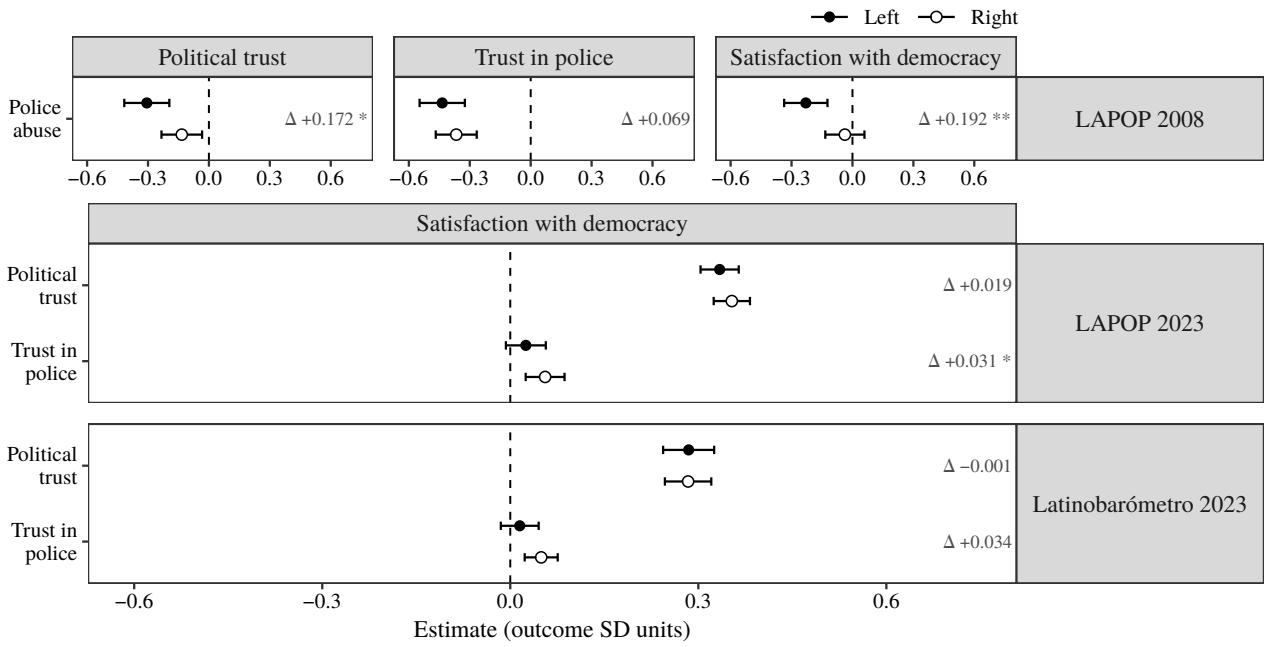
Ordering	Direct	Indirect	Total	% mediated	E-value	Benchmark RR
Panel A: LAPOP 2008						
A: police abuse → trust in police → political trust → satisfaction	−0.034	−0.078**	−0.112**		1.28	1.08
via trust in police alone		−0.018**		16.1%		
via both in series		−0.060**		53.7%		
via political trust alone	0.002			−1.7%		
direct, net of both	−0.036			32.0%		
B: police abuse → political trust → trust in police → satisfaction	−0.049	−0.063**	−0.112**		1.28	1.08
via political trust alone		−0.058**		51.6%		
via both in series		−0.005**		4.5%		
via trust in police alone	−0.013**			11.7%		
direct, net of both	−0.036			32.2%		
Panel B: LAPOP 2023						
A: trust in police → political trust → satisfaction	0.046**	0.146**	0.193**	75.9%	2.22	1.14
B: political trust → trust in police → satisfaction	0.335**	0.024**	0.359**	6.6%	1.28	1.14
Panel C: Latinobarómetro 2023						
A: trust in police → political trust → satisfaction	0.041**	0.084**	0.124**	67.2%	2.03	1.34
B: political trust → trust in police → satisfaction	0.268**	0.017**	0.284**	5.8%	1.27	1.34

Note: Police abuse is coded 1 if reported. % mediated (2023 rows): indirect share of the total. LAPOP 2008 indented rows split the direct and indirect effects by channel; their four shares sum to 100%. E-value: the smaller of the two path-specific values. Benchmark RR: max(RR, 1/RR) of the strongest measured covariate in 2023 and, in 2008, of the larger of the two measured victimization covariates (police bribe solicitation and crime victimization). $^{**}p < 0.01$ (two-tailed; bootstrap over 1,000 country resamples).

variable reaches only 1.34. For trust in police, the threshold is lower (1.27 and 1.28). A measure whose association with satisfaction operates primarily through another variable should be more sensitive to confounding, pointing to decomposition. For the 2008 police-abuse associations, the SI benchmarks the E-values against the larger of the two measured victimization covariates, police bribe solicitation and crime victimization. Entropy balancing on the observed covariates leaves the sign and approximate magnitude of all three associations unchanged. Taken together, these results indicate that political trust is the more direct conduit for the effect of police violence on satisfaction with democracy, with trust in the police influencing this judgment more indirectly.

Following the literature and mirroring Study 1's moderators as far as these surveys allow, we also test whether these associations vary by ideology and by race. As reported in Figure 4, among left-identified respondents, reporting abuse corresponds to −0.306 (SE 0.057) on political trust and

FIGURE 4. Study 3 Associations by Ideological Self-Placement



Note: Upper block: LAPOP 2008 police-abuse associations; lower block: 2023 trust-to-satisfaction associations. Predictors run down the left, outcomes across the top, and the dataset is given at the right. Left: 0–4 on Latinobarómetro's 0–10 scale and 1–4 on LAPOP's 1–10 scale; right: 6–10. Bars are 95% confidence intervals. Δ: the difference between the two groups, right minus left. Marks refer to that difference, not to the individual associations. $^{*}p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$ (two-tailed; Satterthwaite df). Both blocks span the same horizontal range.

−0.230 (SE 0.054) on satisfaction with democracy, against −0.134 (SE 0.051) and −0.037 (SE 0.049) among right-identified respondents, with $p = .018$ and $p = .007$ for the differences between them. The police trust association does not differ by ideology ($p = .339$).

Ideology conditions the response even when the abuse is personal, since these respondents report police abuse against themselves. We interpret that left-identified victims carry the abuse over to the political system, lowering their political trust and satisfaction with democracy, while right-identified victims confine their judgment to the police at most and leave their evaluations of the system apart.

Through the lens of police trust, the 2023 surveys show that the relationship between police trust and satisfaction is somewhat larger on the right (difference $p = .048$ in LAPOP, $p = .066$ in the Latinobarómetro), while the one with political trust does not differ. The associations are similar for white and non-white respondents: none of the seven differences is distinguishable from zero (p between .22 and .90; SI Figure C2). The SI reports the interaction contrasts (Table C10).

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TABLE 4. How the three studies triangulate the same conclusion

	Exposure	Population	Quantity estimated	Contributes
Study 1	Written scenario of a violent police stop	Brazilian adults, online panel	Randomized effect of indirect exposure	Internal validity
Study 2	Documented repression in the respondent's census zone	Chilean panel respondents, 2016–2019	Difference-in-differences effect of local exposure	Ecological validity
Study 3	Personal victimization reported by the respondent	LAPOP respondents in fifteen countries	Covariate-adjusted association	External validity

Note: All three studies point toward lower democratic satisfaction. Study 1's full-sample political trust estimate is negative but does not meet the 5% threshold; Study 2's trust in the police estimate is indistinguishable from zero, and its political trust and satisfaction results arise in municipalities where protest did not surge. Specifications, samples, and estimates appear in the study sections and the SI.

DISCUSSION

In our studies, police violence had a spillover effect on citizens' evaluation of the regime, by lowering trust in institutions that had no direct part in the violence and their satisfaction with democracy itself. By spillover we mean that police violence lowers evaluations beyond the police, not that trust in the police, political trust and satisfaction with democracy fall in a fixed order. In the terms of Norris (1999), the damage spreads from the police to other regime institutions and up to evaluations of regime performance. We summarize our conclusions in Table 4, showing the design of each study and its contribution.

The common directional pattern across studies is on satisfaction with democracy, the outcome that matters most for our argument: it decreases under experimental treatment in Brazil and after local exposure in Chilean municipalities where protest did not surge, and it is negatively associated with self-reported abuse in the cross-national study. Each study has limitations, but they differ across studies. Study 1 uses random assignment, but the exposure is a written scenario, and, although it suggests a real-life effect, it cannot provide evidence of what happens in real life. Study 2 measures repression that actually happened, which the survey experiment cannot do. The estimate relies on comparing exposed areas with nearby areas that were not exposed. However, where protests did surge, repression may have spilled over into the nearby areas of the same municipality that we count as unexposed, weakening the comparison. Study 3 analyzes fifteen countries and the respondents' self-reported victimization, but it is limited to observational conclusions because it lacks a counterfactual. Overall, we find it

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unlikely that their separate weaknesses would all bias the results in the same direction since they rely on different designs and contexts.

Consistent with our theory, the violent vignette in Brazil eroded perceptions of procedural justice, and in the cross-national data about half of the association between police abuse and satisfaction with democracy runs through political trust. The moderation results also support the process we theorize behind the main effects on satisfaction with democracy. Across studies, the clearest moderation appears for trust in the police, the attitude closest to the event. In Brazil the vignette decreased pro-PT, non-white, and high-trait-aggression respondents' trust the most, while in Chile the one clean subgroup contrast was the vote for who commanded the violence. Direct victimization tells a different story, in which all victims lost trust in the police at similar rates, and this null cannot be attributed to thin data because the cross-national sample is our largest. Our interpretation is that a person the police mistreated knows who the agent of the violence is, whereas a person hearing about violence at a distance must decide what to make of it. However, we do find that victims' politics shaped how far the spillover to the regime went, as ideology among victims moderated the relationship with political trust and satisfaction with democracy, but race did not.

This political pattern in moderation also has implications. Trust in the police is usually understood as an evaluation of performance, but our evidence suggests it also reflects political loyalty, since in both single-country studies, respondents aligned with the side that champions the police lost less trust in it. In Chile, Piñera voters' trust in the police survived exposure that lowered it among everyone else; in Brazil, the vignette moved anti-PT respondents about half as far as their pro-PT counterparts. Because the item is a standard fixture of comparative surveys, analyses that treat it purely as a performance measure will absorb some political sorting into what they report as assessments of policing. One possibility is that, in Latin America, concerns over police violence have long been part of the left's agenda, so the negative evaluations might be on the left. Alternatively, it may reflect loyalty to the side that champions the police, whichever side governs. In the periods we study, the salient champions of the police in Brazil and Chile were on the right, and the two mechanisms therefore predict the same observations.

Our contribution is to move police violence into the study of democracy. In our results, the damage

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caused by police violence extends to the institutions of the regime itself, under three kinds of exposure and in multiple countries. Because the police are the state institution that most citizens deal with, we expect the same spillover outside Latin America. Future research could investigate which institutional settings weaken the connection between police conduct and regime assessment and support. Political systems across the region and the world differ in how well they are able to absorb shocks of this kind and, consequently, avoid the spillover. Identifying the sources of those differences is the natural extension of these results.

CONCLUSION

In this article, we asked whether police violence produces spillover effects on attitudes that sustain democracy. We answered it with a randomized vignette in Brazil, geocoded records of repression during Chile's *estallido social*, and self-reported victimization across fifteen Latin American countries with available survey data. The experiment in Brazil found lower democratic satisfaction, local exposure in Chile was followed by lower satisfaction in municipalities where protest did not surge, and, finally, self-reported police abuse victimization was negatively associated with satisfaction in the cross-national study.

We provide evidence that exposure to police violence worsens citizens' evaluations of democratic institutions and of democracy itself, in the same direction in every setting we examined. These results should not be compared in magnitude, because the different exposures and instruments of each study make the estimates non-commensurable. We also do not draw any policy conclusions, since none of our designs estimates the consequences of any particular reform or predicts the political moderation under governments of different ideologies.

However, right-wing Latin American political elites often defend *mano dura* policing, a set of reforms that open the door to police abuse, as the remedy for high levels of criminality (Holland 2013). Our results suggest a cost that is rarely mentioned on either side of this debate: police violence weakens satisfaction with democracy and can erode trust in its main institutions. Recent reviews of what police violence does to citizens center instead on their health and their trust in the police (DeVylder et al. 2022; Haile et al. 2023; Nägel and Nivette 2023). The cost to institutions might be only

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for certain groups, but the cost to satisfaction with democracy affects everyone. In Brazil and in the cross-national data, the political damage was larger among citizens on the left, and in the experiment it further concentrated among non-whites and among the dispositionally aggressive. Police violence may therefore do more than lower average support for the regime and also sort disaffection along political cleavages, concentrating lower trust among the groups that prior research identifies as the most exposed to this violence and the most critical of it. That is, what police violence does to citizens' trust in democratic institutions also belongs in the debate about *mano dura* policies' consequences.

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

Research documentation and data that support the findings of this study will be openly available in the *American Political Science Review* Dataverse upon publication. The deposit will include the Study 1 experimental data and materials, the code for all three studies, the census-zone crosswalk we built for the ELSOC respondents from ELSOC's territorial indicators and the 2017 Census, and the zone-level exposure we coded from INDH records. The ELSOC, LAPOP, and Latinobarómetro surveys are available from their providers.

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